life. He set the presses rolling on the first issue of the youth journal ‘Neues Leben’ by appealing for readers to work shoulder to shoulder in clearing away the ‘visible and invisible debris of the past from the streets and from people’s minds’. We would, he recorded, ‘have to put in our best efforts to bring about the reconstruction of town and countryside’.15 Since the cessation of hostilities in Berlin, every kind of public service had been either seriously impaired or left unworkable and accommodation for those who survived was often primitive in the extreme. After entering Berlin, it took the Russians six weeks to get electricity and water supplies functioning to a reasonable degree, while sanitary engineers endeavoured to purify the water supply. But, amid the filth and misery, signs of recovery emerged. Pubs and makeshift canteens served construction workers, along with barter markets springing up everywhere. On the outskirts, lakeside beaches attracted bathers on warmer days and at one of Berlin’s biggest libraries – where huge shell holes were blown into the walls – a lending service operated from the basement.

As well as helping in the clean-up effort, FDJ members deployed in June 1946 to deliver propaganda in a campaign calling for a referendum in Saxony ‘to expropriate war criminals and Nazis’. With 77 per cent of voters in favour of nationalisation, the ballot retrospectively legitimised the confiscation of thousands of companies by the Soviet occupying power the previous year. Without any further referenda, nationalisations were expanded to the entire occupation zone. The action came ahead of the first so-called ‘parliament’ of the FDJ from 8 to 10 June 1946, when the political character of the organisation became abundantly clear. Honecker chose the term ‘parliament’ deliberately to show off the ‘democratic nature’ of the FDJ.

Watching the parliament, William Forrest, a British journalist, was struck by ‘the storm of applause which greeted the appearance on the platform of Wilhelm Pieck and Otto Grotewohl, joint leaders of the communist-inspired Socialist Unity Party’. Reporting that ‘this showed where the political sympathies of the delegates lay’. The keynote speaker, Colonel Tolpanov from the Soviet Military Government – a loud, brash, man with a penchant for large cigars – rhapsodized that the young must imbibe the culture of the whole world and ‘above all the most progressive culture in the world, the